

EPISODE ONE

The premise

v8.1, 2026-08-31. Title ruled: The Friends with Four Keys. Two lines updated for the spine's Ruling 8 (Stephen-worded): the exit runs on a missing man's genuine name, and Violet was not his first. Otherwise v8, closed to premise-level attack 2026-08-30.

What changed since v7. ChatGPT attacked v7 and returned REWORK with eight findings. All eight were taken through one at a time on 30 August. Three were closed by Stephen's own additions rather than by GPT's proposed repairs: Violet's letter says *I think*, not *I know*; there is a genuine object behind the door as well as the forged letter, and the object is a decoy; and Margo's private channel already existed, for Tessa. One was conceded outright: the police examine the letter, and it passes.

Names. Fable wrote the five as people before any of this plot existed and was never told who did it. Stephen chose the final names: Violet Moore, Liam Bryce, Ruby Walker, Margo Rivera, Brad Collins. The casting is Stephen's.

Violet dies in her own home, at the foot of her own stairs. Blunt force trauma to the head, which is exactly what a fall like that leaves, and exactly what something else leaves too. Police attend, there is a post-mortem, and a coroner records an accident, because a shove down a staircase and a slip on one are the same injury. Nobody is incompetent. Within a few weeks it is simply a sad thing that happened to somebody.

She had four close friends: **Liam, Ruby, Margo and Brad**. In the months before she died Violet had come to believe that one of those four was planning to kill her. She did not know which, and she was not certain. What she had found was a thing, not a fact: one object, meaningless on its own, damning if the four of them put what they each separately knew of her beside it. She could not take it to the police, and she had thought that through. They would take all four of her friends apart, find nothing, close it in a week, and whoever it was would know she knew. So she hid it, and she made an arrangement.

After the funeral, four keys arrive in the post, each with a letter in her hand. The letter says: I think one of you is planning to kill me. I do not know which, and I may be wrong. Do not go to the police, and here is why. What I found is behind this door. Only the four of you can read it.

They ring each other that night. They agree to go together, on Saturday. Three of them keep the agreement. One goes early, and then goes again on Saturday with the others, as if for the first time.

What they find is a letter in her hand, and beside it a thing of hers. The letter does not name anyone. It says she knows, now, not thinks. It sets out what she noticed, piece by piece, and tells them what the thing beside it means, and leaves them to work through the rest. Everyone in the room recognises the object as Violet's, because it is. It is not the letter she wrote. Brad wrote it, in the days between the post and Saturday, in a hand nobody knew he had, from the sample she had sent him himself, on paper from her unit. The object is real; only its meaning is his. What Violet actually hid is in his possession, and he has no intention of destroying it.

So four people who loved her spend weeks in a room working a dead woman's letter and a dead woman's object, and holding two readings at once: she was right, or she was frightened and then she fell. Ruby cannot bear the second, because it means she stood in that kitchen a hundred times and saw nothing, and Ruby is

who drives things. The reading bends, slowly, towards Liam. **Brad is the one who will not have it.** She might have been wrong about all of it, he says. We cannot do this to Liam on a maybe. He argues Liam's side every time it comes up, and he loses every time, and every time the reading comes back to where it was.

Margo gets close, and she gets there because of the one thing Violet told her and nobody else. The object is Violet's, but it cannot mean what the letter says it means, because Margo knows where Violet's money came from, and the letter has it wrong. So the letter is wrong about the object. But the letter is in Violet's hand, and Violet did not lie to them. So the letter is not Violet's. And if it is not, someone put it there, before Saturday, and left a real thing of hers beside it to make it true. A key means a thing, and the thing behind that door was a decoy, so the real thing is gone. She goes back through everything the letter has made them think, and the one person she keeps arriving at is the one who kept the room on Liam by defending him. She says nothing, because the man the letter points at is innocent and the man she suspects is her friend. But she stops arguing with Brad, and she stops looking at the other two, and Brad notices.

A few days later Brad disappears. His car is found near the coast, at a spot the whole city knows people go to when they want to end things. His phone is on the seat with one message on it: he cannot do this any more. His watch, the one he never took off, is on the rocks below, smashed. No body is recovered, which is normal there. Police search his flat and take the toothbrush and the razor they take when a body might wash up next year. When the rent stops, the landlord clears it, and Ruby keeps the boxes. His accounts are never touched again. The city settles on grief.

And Margo stops. There are only two ways to read it. Either she was wrong about him, or she was right and she made a man jump off a cliff. She cannot live inside the second one, so she chooses the first. It never stops bothering her. She has told one person, on the channel she has used for eleven years for the one person the others do not know exists: *the thing in the cupboard is wrong. It can't mean that.* She never says who she thinks put it there.

The three of them keep working the letter, and it is Ruby who drives it now. It lands on Liam. Even Brad could not make it not fit, and it broke him. Liam knows the letter is Violet's hand and knows it cannot mean him, so somebody is reading it to fit, and the person who ran the reading is the person who ran every meeting. He does not go to the police, because the only thing he could hand them is a letter in a dead woman's hand that points at him. Margo watches it land on a man she believes is innocent, and the only alternative she has is a man she believes she killed. She cannot say either.

Months later a stranger begins talking to Margo, on that same channel, from a number that leads nowhere. He knows things about Brad's death that nobody has said out loud, and everything he offers points her gently somewhere else. Everything he sends deletes itself. When it becomes clear that she is not being turned, he tells her he will meet her and give her the rest, and he names the place: the spot where the car was found.

She goes.

Margo's body washes up in Havenbay harbour a few days later. Her phone does not. There is nothing about her injuries that a fall does not explain, so nobody thinks she was pushed and they assume she jumped. And everybody has a reason ready, because she had spent months blaming herself for the friend who went off the same cliff.

Liam is afraid of Ruby. Ruby is afraid of Liam. For opposite reasons, and both of them wrong. And each of them is frightened enough to break Violet's last instruction and walk into a police station with the letters and say so. Not "he did it". "I am frightened of him."

The police look, properly. They have an accident, a presumed suicide, and a suicide, two survivors accusing each other, a frightened woman's letter that says *I think*, and a second letter both survivors swear is in her hand. They have it examined. It is consistent with her known samples, because the man who wrote it was taught by her and wrote it on her paper with her pen. They review Margo's last movements and find a phone at the bottom of the sea and a partner nobody in Havenbay knew about. They find nothing, because there is nothing where they are looking. It is front page news, and Ally's podcast picks it up a day later.

And this is what she walks into. Two people who have not been charged with anything and never will be, being taken apart in public by each other and by an entire city.

Brad is alive. He is four hundred miles away under a name that was never his, living on cash he put aside before Violet died, in a room he arranged before he needed it. His passport and his cards were in the flat when the police searched it. Nobody helped him. He thinks it is finished, and he is not wrong to think so. He killed Violet, he swapped what she left for a letter that did his pointing for him and a thing of hers that made it true, he removed the one person who saw through it, and he left the last two doing the rest of the work.

Ally comes to all of this afterwards. She prevents nothing, and she could not have. What her podcast does, slowly, is turn *I think* into *she was right*, an accident back into a murder, and a dead man back into a living one. She does not do it alone. Her listeners do it. A woman two hours up the coast, who nobody in the story knows exists, who kept a message: *the thing in the cupboard is wrong*. Ally puts it on air. If the thing behind that door was a decoy, there was a real thing, and nobody has found it. She describes it, from the people who saw it in Violet's life before it went behind that door. One of a kind.

Brad is listening. He gets rid of the thing the same day. He knows somebody near him could have seen it. He cannot know who. He stays, because leaving costs him everything he built, and because he is cleverer than a podcast.

Everything Ally learns goes to Del first and never on air. And a woman four hundred miles away, who has been listening for six weeks, who half-saw a memorial photo and dismissed it, who has been hearing a man's habits and phrases and stories described by strangers, hears that object described and thinks: no. She looks for it the next morning, where it has always been, and it is gone. She writes to Ally that night. Ally tells Del. The next episode is indistinguishable from the last one. The sample the police took to identify his body identifies him alive.

He notices her the way he noticed Margo. This time she has already spoken.

Who Brad is

A man who genuinely believed he was cleverer than everybody around him, and hid it behind a trade and a van so that nobody would ever check. Some listeners will suspect him early; the story does not depend on their not doing so, because the thing nobody suspects is that he is alive. The tell that reads backwards is that every time the room drifted away from Liam, it was Brad's reasonableness that brought it home.

And Violet was not his first. The name he lives under belonged to a deckhand who lodged his dry bag at Brad's flat, went missing three years before Violet, and was filed as drifted. Nobody ever looked, which is how Brad learned what Kestrel Head keeps.

He was wrong about one thing. He built the letter from what Violet had told him about the other three, and it was good enough to hold three people for weeks. But she had not told him everything. The piece she withheld,

she gave to Margo.

What it is about

He weaponised what they loved. Violet's love sent four keys instead of a phone call to the police. The four's trust made them work his letter. Liam's and Ruby's loyalty to a dead friend did his pointing for him. Margo's guilt kept her quiet, and her secrecy gave him a private line to her. He could work a room. He could not work a crowd of people who did not know one another, four hundred miles apart, who acted before he could learn which of them had seen him. What beat him was distance, plurality and speed.

Still open, so you know what you can change

- **The title: RULED, Stephen, 2026-08-31. *The Friends with Four Keys*. *Five Keys After Midnight* and *The Friend They Mourned* are retired.** Fable's eight alternatives are recorded in the cold-open v0.3 file.
- **What Violet hid.** Its shape is fixed (below) and the object is not chosen. Decided at the spine, and never told to Fable.
- **The decoy.** A genuine thing of Violet's that Brad had access to; the letter gives it a false meaning that points at Liam through something Violet told Brad, and fails through something she told only Margo. The money is the obvious axis: Liam secretly owns a third of the yard, and Margo alone knows where Violet's came from. Chosen at the spine.
- **Why Brad wanted Violet dead.** Not the object; the plan came first. Fable has seeded that Violet had more money than anyone knew.
- **How long ago all of this happened,** and how long Ally's podcast runs for.
- **Which of Liam or Ruby comes to Ally,** and whether either of them is anything to her already.
- **Where in Havenbay it sits,** including which stretch of coast and where the cupboard is.
- **How it ends,** and what it costs.
- **Havenbay rulings needed at the spine:** what supports an accidental-fall finding and what reopens it · missing-person status, searches and reference samples when there is no body · who can petition to have a missing man declared dead · whether authentication of a material posthumous document is routine, discretionary or on-dispute (the letter passes in all three cases) · what a last-movements review reaches on an apparent suicide when the device is lost · whether a death at a known disappearance site automatically links the cases.

The shape of what she hid, fixed: a unique physical object that cannot be posted or copied · meaningless alone, damning beside what the four separately knew · not the motive · something Violet could plausibly have found · something he wants · innocuous in a stranger's house four hundred miles away · describable by Ally without ever holding it.

Settled, and expensive to move: four friends rather than five · Violet's death recorded as an accident after a competent inquiry · her injury one that a fall fully explains · Violet not knowing which of the four, and her letter saying *I think* · the letters creating the suspects and telling them not to go to the police · the four agreeing to go together and one going early · the cupboard swapped, not emptied: a forged letter that says *I know* beside a genuine object with a false meaning · the object pointing at Liam through what Violet told Brad

and failing through what she told only Margo · the letter examined by police and passing · Brad defending Liam, on the ground that she might have been wrong, to make the reading land on him · Brad vanishing before it lands · Liam held by self-interest, not obedience · the phone as the note, the watch as the proof, no written note · the flat searched and cleared, the reference sample as the verification · Margo's private channel pre-existing, for Tessa, and Brad using it from a cash number · Margo's phone lost in the sea · Margo telling Tessa the thing was wrong and never who · Brad's exit prepared long before Violet died, just in case it was ever needed. The exit was the genuine name of a missing man only he knew was dead, with no accomplice · the hidden object kept, not destroyed, and recognised by a stranger · the woman's window measured in hours, the object's absence as her confirmation · tips to Del and never on air · Ally arriving after all of it · the listeners finding the pieces.